

Cover story **PUNE BLAST**

TERROR Tangle

For a city on the terror radar since 26/11, the security proved remarkably porous. Strands of the terror web uncovered by investigators seem linked to past attacks.

By Bhavna Vij-Aurora in Delhi
and Nishika Patel in Pune

In the city reeling from its worst-ever terror attack, investigators have begun their quest to put the pieces together. The Maharashtra Anti-Terror Squad (ATS) is digging into old files, revisiting previous cases and even interrogating those lodged in jails all over the country in connection with other blasts.

So far the only thing that the investigators are willing to say with some amount of certainty was that it was an Indian Mujahideen-Lashkar-e-Toiba (IM-LET) sponsored attack and that it appeared to have been carried out based on reconnaissance by Pakistan-born Lashkar operative David Coleman Headley as part of the Karachi Project. However, with Indo-Pakistan foreign secretary-level talks scheduled for February 25, the Centre and the state stopped short of pointing fingers at Pakistan. Special Inspector General of Police (Law and Order) Rashmi Shukla says, "It is premature to say which outfit was involved. We have not ruled out anything. There have been no arrests and no detentions."

The Central intelligence agencies had not disregarded claims of a Lashkar offshoot, LET Al Alami, for carrying out the blast, and were still verifying the antecedents of the relatively new outfit. Though the ATS had detained and questioned several people, it was yet to make a formal arrest. It was homing in on IM chief Riyaz Bhatkal and bomb maker Subhan Qureshi aka Tauqeer as possible culprits behind the Pune attack. Another IM operative Mohsin Chaudhary, belonging to Pune, was a prime suspect. Chaudhary was also a



Investigators claim the explosive was a deadly corn

key suspect in the Delhi and Ahmedabad serial blasts in 2008. However, the ATS does not have any technical data, as of now, to support this claim. The Home Ministry, on its part, was also under pressure to nail the culprits at the earliest and preempt more attacks before beginning talks with Pakistan. At the same time, efforts were also being made to seek evidence about Pakistan's possible involvement in the blasts so that terror could be placed on top of the agenda.

The ATS had also restarted investigations into the Malegaon and Jaipur

blasts. They were busy tracking IM operatives lodged in jails in different parts of the country. The Maharashtra ATS team was set to quiz Shahzad, an IM operative, accused in the Delhi serial blasts of 2008 and for shooting Delhi Police inspector M.C. Sharma in the Batla House encounter on September 19, 2008. Mohammad Amjad Khwaja, said to be the No. 2 in IM and currently in Hyderabad jail, was also to be questioned by the ATS. Sources said that Intelligence Bureau had suggested that the ATS interrogate Sadiq Sheikh, Mansoor Peerbhoy, the